Wood for defences and drains seems an odd choice of material for the purposes at hand, but it was a carefully thought out choice. The wood used, that of the sal tree, is unusually hard and possesses the high survival capacity required in Pataliputra, which then had, as Patna does today, a high level of subsoil water. In fact, in the 1926–7 excavations of Manoranjan Ghosh on behalf of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) at Bulandibagh, deep ponds of water had to first be baled out before digging could begin.[28] The watery surroundings of Patna were known to cause waterlogging, which was why wood was used for defences and drains. Interestingly, these walls of wooden planks that have since turned up in numerous localities in Patna were not visible to the first archaeological explorers of the city. J.D. Beglar's 1872–3 account categorically stated that in modern Patna he failed to 'discover a single relic, or any traces of the great edifices' that were supposed to have been built there. This he explained with his hypothesis that the ancient city had been washed away by the Ganga.[29] Beglar, an assistant to Alexander Cunningham, Director General of the ASI, did not in this instance display the archaeological intuition of his superior, whose skill in discovering archaeological corroboration for literary descriptions at ancient sites was legendary. A couple of decades later Laurence Austin Waddell, a lieutenant colonel associated with the Indian Medical Service, who had a keen interest in the history of Buddhism and Patna, found substantial 'portions of the old wooden walls of the city described by Megasthenes.'[30] These regularly came to light when villagers dug wells: 'On striking these great beams standing erect so many feet below the surface the superstitious villagers, unable to account for the presence of the huge posts, usually abandon their attempted wells.'[31] Later, many more features of these intriguing structures were excavated by officers of the ASI. But by then the palisades had paled into the background as the remains of a large pillared hall of Mauryan times emerged out of the locality of Kumrahar.[32]